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Rebel Blood

The evidence, therefore, shows that Bhagat Singh's life in revolution was forged on the anvil of the master workmen in his family. These included his grandfather, father and his two uncles. Without them, his initial sensibilities in relation to a Punjab in turmoil would not have developed so early in life. This perspective on his life is not always understood, as the focus is on his later years when, after his arrest on 8 April 1929, he went into prison until he was put to death on 23 March 1931. During this time he read some 300 books and imbibed the revolutionary fervour of many anarchists and communists from across the world. He was influenced by these books, but the seeds of his resistance were already sown in him through family upbringing. This thesis is not entirely uncontested. In his masterly *India's Revolutionary Inheritance*, the author Chris Moffat is sceptical about Punjabi anecdotes that suggest that Bhagat Singh's pronounced anti-colonial resistance 'was ingrained in his conscience from the very beginning'. [1] After all, Bhagat Singh borrowed widely from other transnational insurgents in the USA, Europe and Russia. For this reason, he takes a jaundiced view of hagiographers' tendency 'to point to Bhagat Singh's "rebel blood' [2]: or, in less sensational terms, to a childhood spent amid a politically active family'. Nevertheless, Moffat's meticulous research does not blind him to how Bhagat Singh's father Kishan Singh was so 'frequently at odds with the colonial regime' [3] that after the Punjab agrarian revolt of 1907 he was even mentioned in James Ker's report for the Criminal Intelligence Department. [4] In that report, Kishan Singh is held personally responsible for 'flooding the Punjab with seditious literature'. [5] On this basis, Moffat recognizes how, for many in Punjab, '[i]t is the